

will also need to be fed with a high-potash fertilizer in spring.

To discourage the spread of diseases such as silver leaf, always prune in early spring and summer. Cherries, like other stone fruit trees, produce their crop on year-old wood, so prune to remove old, fruited wood and to train the tree into shape. Cherries are commonly grown as fans or pyramids (see pruning tip box, left).

Cover both sweet and sour cherries with fleece while the delicate flowers are blossoming. Trees will also need netting to deter birds, as these will happily strip the tree of all of its fruits.

HARVESTING

When they are ripe, cut the cherries from the tree with their stalks attached using scissors or pruning shears. Hold the fruits by the stalks while you cut them to prevent the fruit from dropping and becoming damaged. You may need to go over the tree several times to collect the entire harvest.

STORING

Cherries do not store well after harvesting, so eat them fresh as soon as possible, use them for cooking or making preserves, or freeze them for later use.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Sudden changes in moisture levels can cause the cherries' skins to split, leaving them vulnerable to wasps and flies. To discourage this, ensure that you water the tree regularly and do not let it dry out. Net the trees to deter birds, and be wary of other pests such as aphids and fruit flies. If you spot signs of these, spray the affected trees with an appropriate insecticide.

Cherry trees are prone to diseases such as bacterial canker, silver leaf, and brown rot (see below). To discourage the emergence or spread of disease, practice good garden hygiene: ensure that the trees have sufficient ventilation and space, always prune with sterilized equipment, and remove and destroy any affected fruits, foliage, or branches promptly.



Cherries affected by brown rot shrivel and develop creamy-white spots.